Module09 – Interaction Design Critique and Iteration

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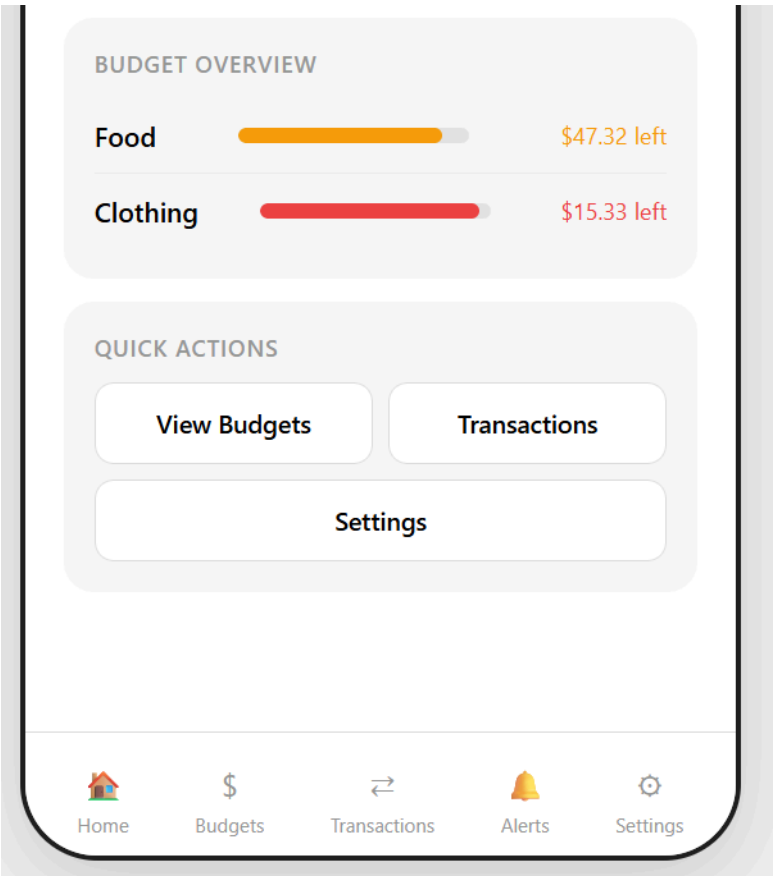
Previous URL (“after” for module 8):
https://laws-smith-luna.github.io/User-Interface-Design/after/

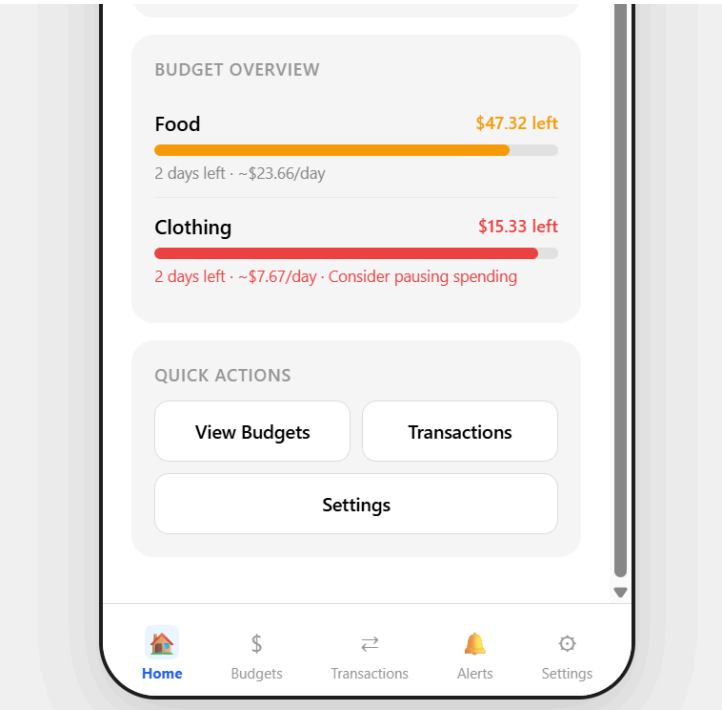
New URL: https://laws-smith-luna.github.io/User-Interface-Design/after-m9/

Weakness 1: Bottom navigation never indicates the active section



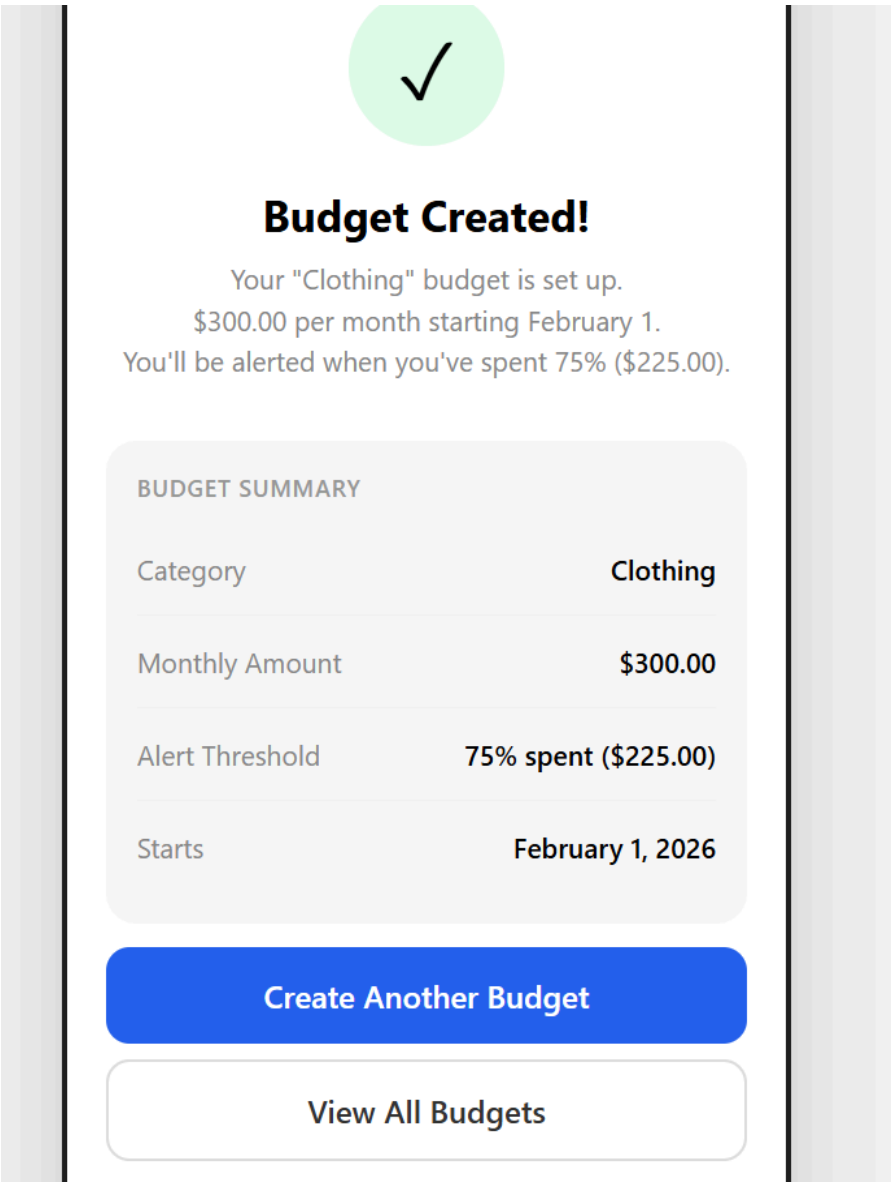
The bottom navigation bar contains five items (Home, Budgets, Transactions, Alerts, Settings), but none of them visually highlight to show the user which section they are currently viewing. When looking at the Dashboard, the Home icon is not highlighted. When viewing the Transactions list, the Transactions icon looks the same as every other tab. Krug emphasizes in *Don't Make Me Think* that navigation must always communicate where the user currently is, similar to a "You Are Here" marker on a map. Without this feedback, users lose their sense of

place in the app. This is especially problematic after an interruption, since there is no visual cue to remind them where they left off.

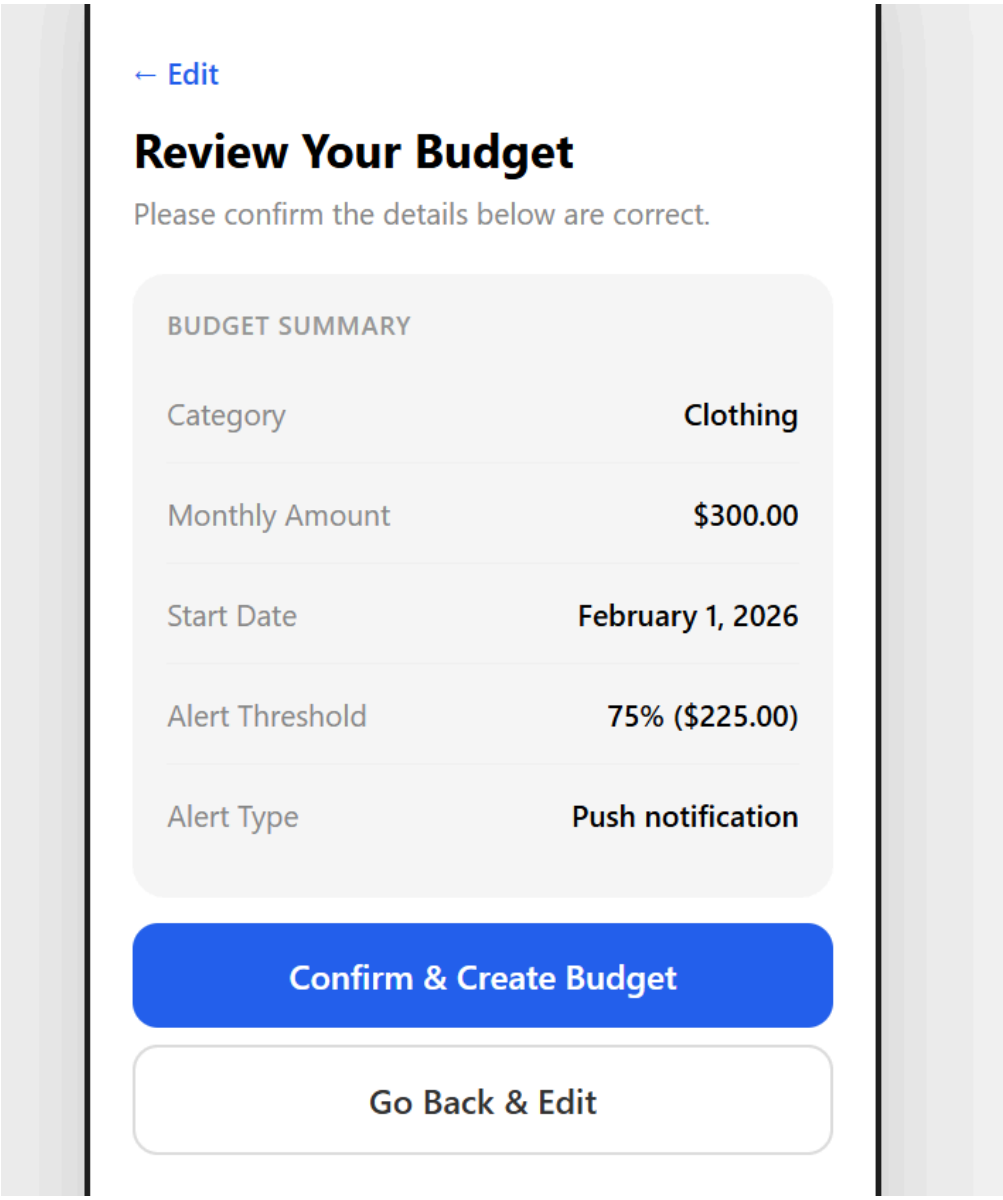


The active bottom navigation item is now visually highlighted with a colored icon and label (blue for the active section) while inactive items remain gray. This provides continuous location feedback so the user always knows which section of the app they are viewing, regardless of how they navigated there or how long they've been away.

Weakness 2: No confirmation step before creating a budget

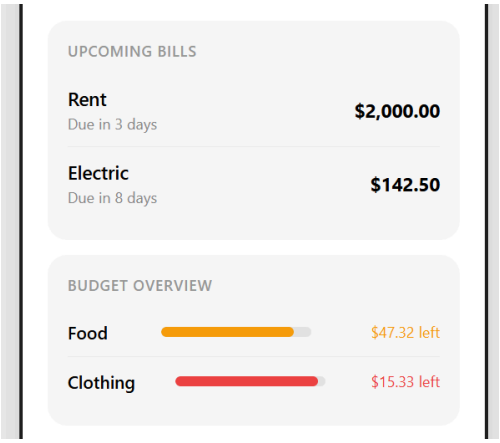


Tapping "Create Budget" on the form immediately commits the action with no review or confirmation step. If the user accidentally selects the wrong category, enters the wrong dollar amount, or picks the wrong alert threshold, the budget is created instantly. The success screen that follows shows a summary of what was created, but it offers no "Edit" or "Undo" option to correct a mistake. Norman argues in Chapter 5 of *The Design of Everyday Things* that for actions with meaningful consequences, the system should request confirmation to help catch mistakes before they become committed errors. Setting a monthly budget is a financial decision that shapes how the app tracks and alerts the user going forward, so an accidental misconfiguration could go unnoticed for weeks.

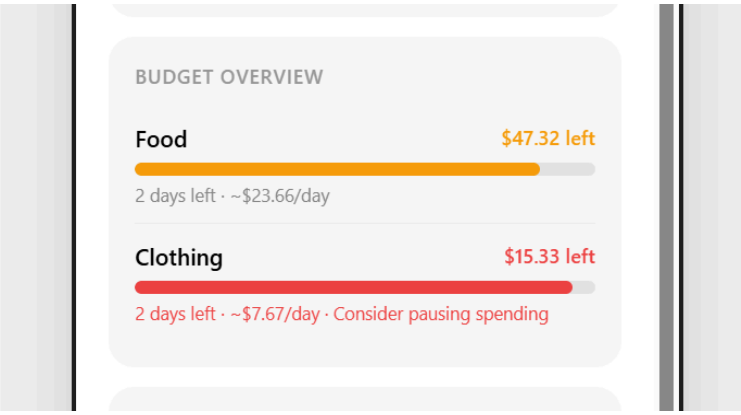


A review step now appears after the user taps "Create Budget," showing a summary of the category, amount, start date, and alert threshold with a clear "Confirm" button and a "Go Back" option. This gives the user a chance to catch mistakes before the budget is finalized. The success screen also now includes an "Edit Budget" link so the user can still correct it without deleting and recreating.

Weakness 3: Dashboard budget bars give no spending pace context

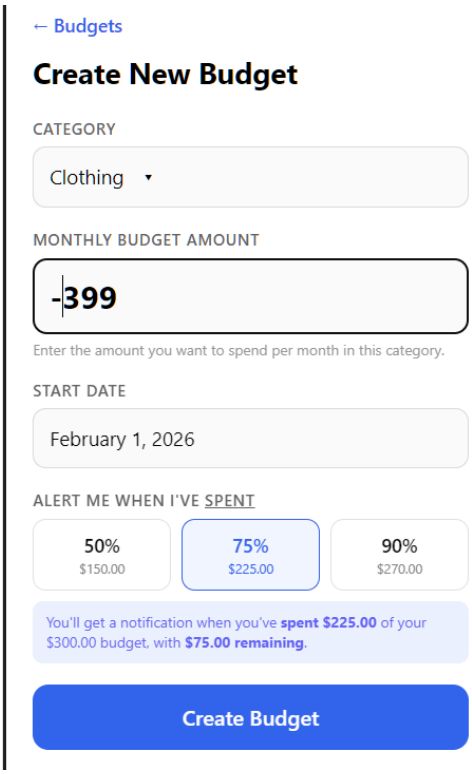


The Budget Overview section on the Dashboard shows colored progress bars and how much money remains in each category, but it provides no context about whether the user's spending pace is sustainable for the rest of the month. For example, the Food budget shows "$47.32 left" with a yellow bar, but the user has no way of knowing whether that amount needs to last 2 days or 15 days without doing the math themselves. The principle of visibility of system status from the Interaction Techniques lecture says the system should always keep users informed about what is going on through appropriate feedback. A budget tracker that only shows raw remaining dollars without relating it to time forces users to calculate their own spending rate, which defeats the purpose of the tool.

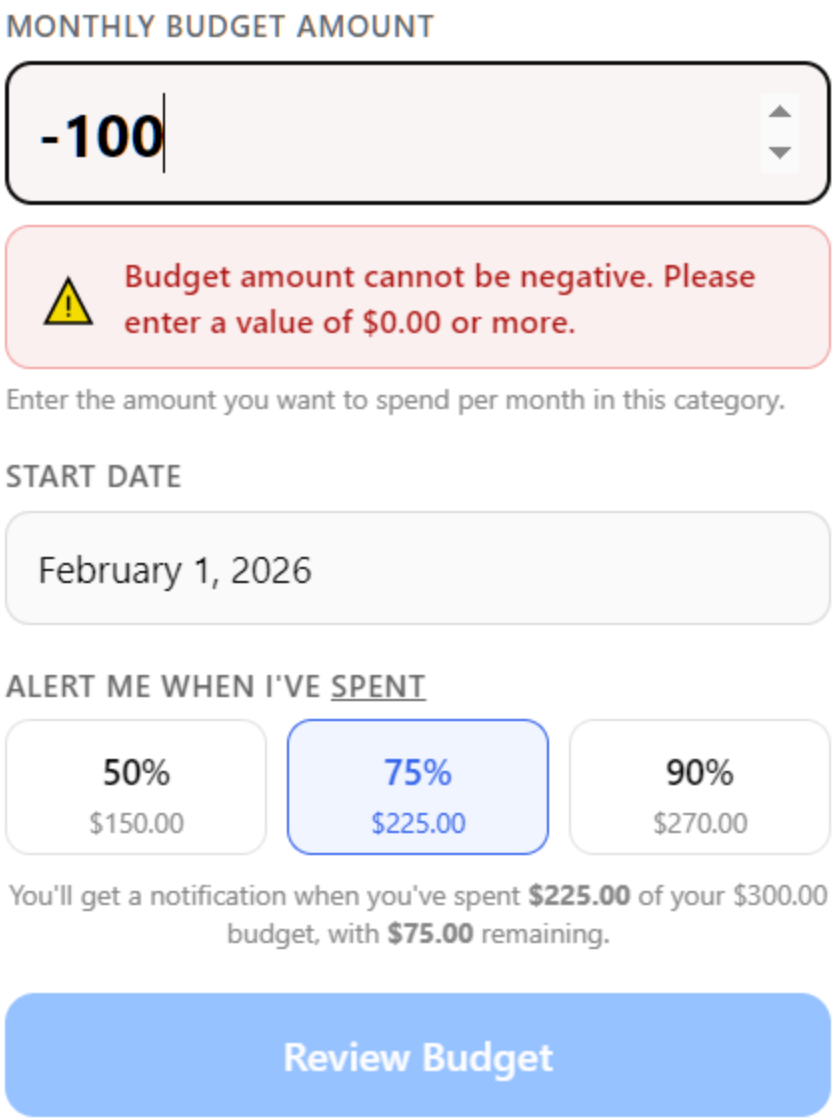


The Budget Overview cards now include a line below each progress bar showing the number of days remaining in the month and the daily spending allowance (e.g., "$47.32 left, 2 days remaining, ~$23.66/day"). This gives users immediate context about whether their current pace is sustainable. The color coding also now factors in pace: a budget with plenty of money but only a few days left stays green, while a budget with the same amount but two weeks remaining turns yellow to signal that spending should slow down.

Weakness 4: No error checking when creating a budget

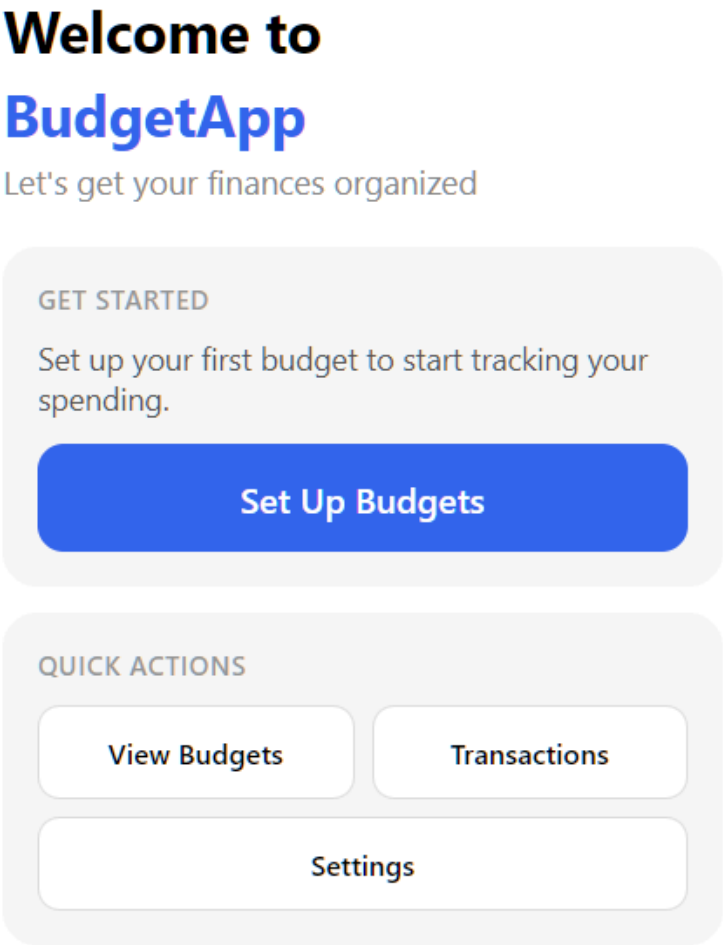


The Create New Budget section allows users to add new budgets to their profile with a chosen category, budget amount, along with other pieces of information. There is no error checking on this section. In the screenshot, we are able to create a new budget with a negative budget amount. This obviously should not be a valid budget amount. In chapter 5 of *The Design of Everyday Things*, Norman states that there should be sensibility checks so that small errors like this do not snowball into bigger issues down the line.

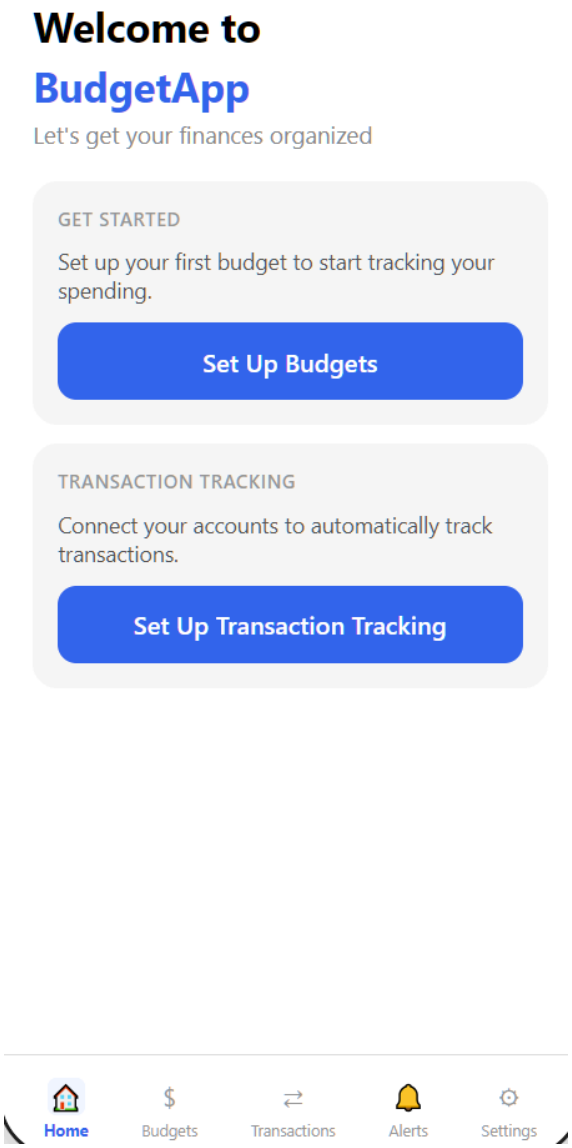


The Create New Budget section now displays a warning when a negative value is entered as a budget amount. Furthermore, the Review Budget button is greyed out, not allowing users to continue until they enter a valid budget amount. Implementing this simple sensibility check stops users from making a small issue that could snowball into a larger one later in the system.

Weakness 5: The initial homepage features unnecessary buttons



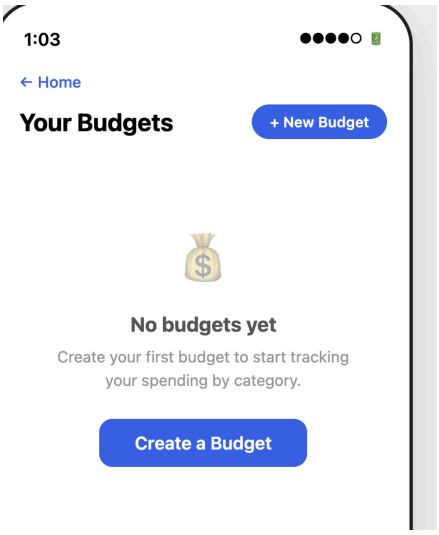
The home page shown to new users presents 4 buttons: “Set Up Budgets”, “View Budgets”, “Transactions”, and “Settings”. However, 2 of these buttons don’t lead to anything meaningful. The “View Budgets” button would just lead new users to a blank page since they have not created any budgets yet, and the transactions button would again result in a blank page since new users would not have set up spending tracking yet. In chapter 7 of *Don’t Make Me Think,* Krug states that you should try to promote everything on the homepage. Applying Krug’s advice to our home page, we shouldn’t try to promote the ability to view budgets and transactions when these actions haven’t been set up yet.

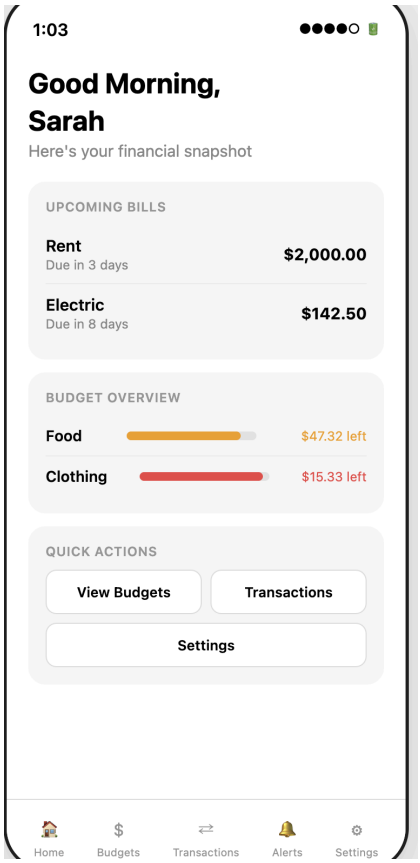


The home page for new users now only has two buttons: “Set Up Budgets” and “Set Up Transaction Tracking”. We removed the “View Budgets” and “Transactions” buttons since they led to nowhere. We also decided to remove the “Settings” button since users can access their settings from the bottom navigation bar, making the button redundant.

Weakness 6: Inconsistent Navigation (The "Back" Button)

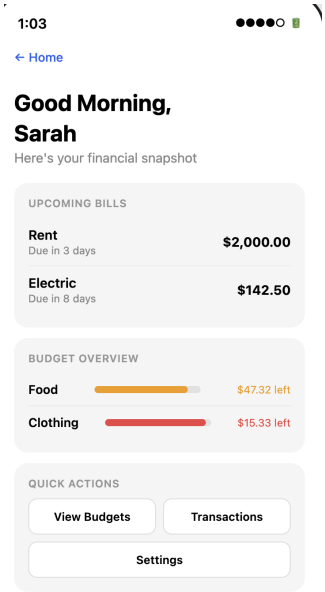
Screenshot of weakness:





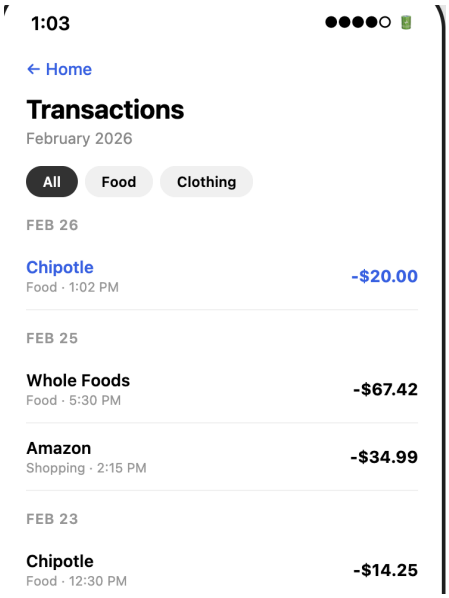
The "Back" button styling and placement are inconsistent. On the Budgets screen, it says "← Home," but on the Dashboard, there is no back button (it relies on the bottom nav). This violates Consistency and Standards. Users expect the navigation hierarchy to remain stable across different functional areas of the site.

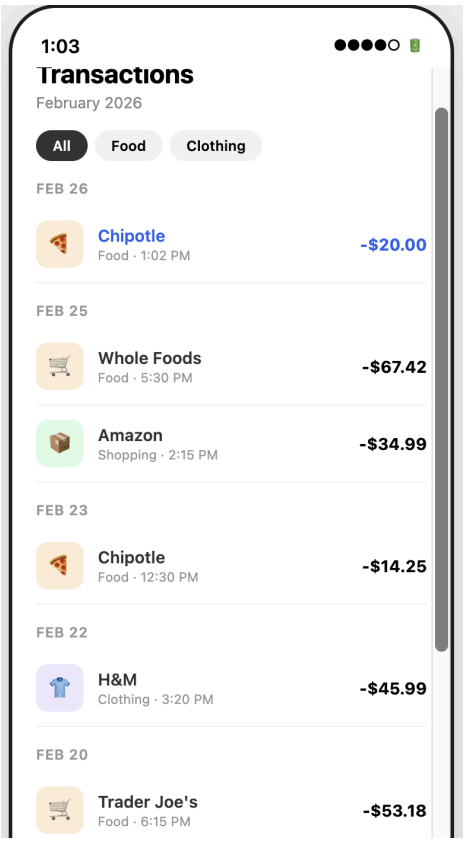
Screenshot of fix:



Weakness 7: Lack of Recognition over Recall (Missing Transaction Visuals)

Screenshot of issue:



The transaction list is a dense, text-only display that forces users to read each line to identify the nature of a purchase, relying on Recall of merchant names rather than Recognition of visual cues. Interaction design guidelines suggest that incorporating category-specific icons (e.g., a fork icon for food) provides a "visual anchor" that allows users to scan the list more efficiently. Without these anchors, the Cognitive Load is unnecessarily high, making it difficult for users to quickly assess their spending patterns at a glance.

Screenshot of fix: